

Contrast via anti-additivity: The cases of Chinese *bìng bù* and Korean *talum anila*

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1. Introduction

Cross-linguistically, **contrastive** (and closely related, **corrective**) **particles** include, e.g., English *but* (Toosarvandani 2014), Italian *ma* (Cinque 1976, Frana & Rawlins 2019), French *mais* (Anscombre & Ducrot 1977), Chinese *bìng bù* (并不) and *yòu bù* (又不) (Yuan & Liu 2025, Wu 2025). Intuitively, these particles typically mark **contrast** (e.g., signaling a twist between clauses) or serve a **corrective** function, countering an expectation.

- (1) a. Mary went to study abroad, and John made a bad decision. **No contrastive effect**
b. Mary went to study abroad, but John made a bad decision. $\sim$ **Contrastive effect**

Felicitous use of these particles is often closely related to sentential negation. For example, in (2) and (3), the use of English *but* involves a pattern ‘*not p but q*’, requiring that the first clause connected by *but* contain sentential negation. Word-internal morphological negation does not meet this requirement (see the use of negatively-flavored prefixes in (2b) and (3b); see Anscombre & Ducrot 1977, Horn 2001, Kasimir 2006, Toosarvandani 2014, Wu 2025).

- (2) a. Max doesn’t like spinach but chard. ‘*not p but q*’: **contrasting *p* with *q***
b. #Max dislikes spinach but chard.
(3) a. Space travel is not possible, but a dream. (Toosarvandani 2014: (69))
b. #Space travel is impossible, but a dream. (Toosarvandani 2014: (69))

Chinese *bìng bù* and *yòu bù* also explicitly include sentence-level negative particle *bù*: i.e., the clause immediately following *bìng* / *yòu* must contain sentential negation.

In *bìng bù*, sometimes, *bù* (不) can be substituted by other sentence-level negative particles like *méi* (yǒu) (没(有)) or *fēi* (非), yielding variations like *bìng méi* (yǒu) (并没(有)) or *bìng fēi* (并非). However, the use of *bìng* along with word-internal morphological negation results in degradedness (see *wèi-bì* ‘unnecessary’ in (4b); *wèi* (未) is a negatively-flavored prefix).

- (4) a. 我们 请了 张三, (但) 她 并 不/非 一定 会 来
wǒ-men qǐng-le Zhāng-Sān (dàn) tā bìng bù/fēi yīdìng huì lái
1PL invite-PFT Zhāng-Sān but 3SG BÌNG NEG necessary can/will come
‘We invited Zhāng Sān, but it’s not necessary that she will come.’
b. 我们 请了 张三, (但) 她 (*并) 未必 会 来
wǒ-men qǐng-le Zhāng-Sān (dàn) tā (*bìng) wèi-bì huì lái
1PL invite-PFT Zhāng-Sān but 3SG BÌNG unnecessary can/will come
Intended: ‘We invited Zhāng Sān, but it’s not necessary that she will come.’

What role does sentential negation play in these uses of contrastive particles? Why is it obligatorily required? How does its presence shed light on the notion of contrast or correction?

In this paper, I focus on the use of Chinese *bìng bù* and extend the discussion to Korean *talum anila* (or *talun-key anila*). I show that both Chinese *bìng bù* and Korean *talum anila* contain **an additive particle** (*bìng*, *talum*) and **a negation operator** (*bù*, *anila*). I propose **anti-additivity** (regarding meaning strengthening) as a mechanism of establishing **contrast**.

The meaning of ‘(q,) *bìng bù* p’ can be paraphrased as ‘(q, but) contrary to what someone might think, $\neg p$ ’. The speaker of ‘(q,) *bìng bù* p’ (i) acknowledges *p* (i.e., the prejacent of *bìng bù*) as a salient implicature (or other salient or likely information) given the current common ground (CG, *q* included), and (ii) explicitly rejects *p* as part of the CG. Similarly, ‘*talum anila*, *q*’ assumes stronger alternatives beyond what is uttered (here *q*) and negates those alternatives.

In using *bìng bù* and *talum anila*, the speaker makes explicit ‘ $q \wedge \neg(q \wedge p)$ ’ (*q* is information already included in the CG). Negation functions to block the strengthening of *q* into $q \wedge p$, thereby enforcing a non-additive interpretation of *q*. The speaker operates this constraint on meaning strengthening at the sentence level as CG management, disrupting interlocutors’ default expectations in interpreting *q* and developing the CG, thus producing a contrastive effect.

Below, §2 presents empirical observations on *bìng bù*. §3 proposes that *bìng bù* is a speaker-oriented, ‘common-ground-management’ operator, rejecting expected implicatures or stronger alternatives that the speaker considers salient for interlocutors. §4 extends the analysis to explain the ‘downplaying’ effect of *bìng bù* and the use of Korean *talum anila*. §5 addresses implications regarding the notion of contrastive meaning in natural language and concludes.

2. Empirical observations on Chinese *bìng bù*

When used alone, *bìng* is not a contrastive particle, but an additive particle (cf. Yuan & Liu 2025, Wu 2025). As illustrated in (5), Chinese *bìng* is similar to English *and* or *along with*.

- (5) 我 昨天 看了 三 本书, 并 做了 笔记
 wǒ zuó-tiān kàn-le sān běn shū bìng zuò-le bǐ-jì
 1SG yesterday read-PFT three CL. book and take-PFT note
 ‘Yesterday I read 3 books and took notes.’ *bìng* is an additive particle

As a contrastive particle, *bìng bù* (or *bìng méi*, *bìng fēi*) contains both an additive particle, *bìng*, and a sentential negation operator, *bù* / *méi* / *fēi*. Unlike the plain negation operator alone, *bìng*+NEG sounds degraded when used out of the blue, as illustrated by (6). Intuitively, a felicitous use of *bìng bù* requires something in the given context to contrast or correct.

- (6) Context: Liz is describing a man she saw. We have no assumptions about this stranger.

Liz: 他 (??并) 没 戴 眼镜
 tā (??bìng) méi dài yǎn-jìng
 3SG BÌNG NEG wear glasses

Intended: ‘He didn’t wear glasses.’ *bìng*+NEG: degraded when used out of the blue

In the recent literature, both Yuan & Liu (2025) and Wu (2025) claim that *bìng bù* is a powerful contrastive particle and can be used to contrast or correct all contextually salient propositional meanings, whether truth-conditions (assertions or presuppositions) or implicatures. Below, I show that such a generalization is not entirely precise and it slightly over-generates.

2.1 Felicitous uses of *bìng bù*: contrasting implicatures *Bìng bù* (or its variants, *bìng méi* (*yǒu*) and *bìng fēi*) can negate, i.e., contrast, a salient implicature. In (7), the proposition ‘I read 3 books’ brings a scalar implicature, ‘I only read 3 books’, and *bìng bù* is felicitously used to negate this scalar implicature. In (8) and (9), *bìng bù* negates a ‘Relevance’-based implicature.¹

- (7) 我看了三本书, (但) 并非只看了三本书
 wǒ kàn-le sān běn shū (dàn) bìng fēi zhǐ kàn-le sān běn shū
 1SG read-PFT three CL. book but BÌNG NEG only read-PFT three CL. book
 ‘I read 3 books, but it’s not the case that I only read 3.’ **Negating a scalar implicature**
- (8) 我看了三本书, (但) 并没看懂
 wǒ kàn-le sān běn shū (dàn) bìng méi kàn dǒng
 1SG read-PFT three CL. book but BÌNG NEG read understand
 ‘I read 3 books, but it’s not that I understood them.’ **Negating a relevant implicature**
- (9) 张三 每天 去健身房 但是他并不健身
 Zhāng-Sān měi-tiān qù jiàn-shēn-fáng dàn-shì tā bìng bù jiàn-shēn
 Zhāng-Sān every-day go gym but 3SG BÌNG NEG work-out
 ‘Zhāng Sān goes to the gym everyday, but he doesn’t work out.’ **Negat. an implicature**

Of course, *bìng bù* can negate an implicature that is an already negated proposition, thus yielding double negation. In (10), the prejacent of *bìng bù* already contains a negation operator, *méi*, so that the part ‘*bìng bù p*’ contains two negation operators: *bù* and *méi*.

- (10) 我昨天看了三本书, (但) 并非没做别的事
 wǒ zuó-tiān kàn-le sān běn shū (dàn) bìng fēi méi zuò bié-de shì
 1SG yesterday read-PFT three CL. book but BÌNG NEG NEG do other thing
 ‘Yesterday I read 3 books, but it’s not that I didn’t do other things.’ **Double negation**

2.2 Infelicitous uses of *bìng bù*: contrasting meanings entailed by one’s own utterance In addition to negating or contrasting a salient implicature, a speaker can felicitously use *bìng bù* to negate an alternative invoked by a focused item, provided that this alternative is not weaker than or entailed by what the speaker has already uttered (i.e., negation cannot lead to contradiction).

As illustrated in (11), *bìng bù* can felicitously negate a stronger, more informative alternative. Here, the stressed item, *sān* (‘three’), invokes a set of alternatives, {one book, two books, three books, four books, ...}. Replacing ‘three books’ with ‘four books’ yields a stronger, more informative proposition, which can be felicitously negated using *bìng bù*. However, as illustrated in (12), using *bìng bù* to negate a weaker, already entailed proposition results in infelicity.

- (11) 我看了三_F本书, (但) 并没看四本书
 wǒ kàn-le sān běn shū (dàn) bìng méi kàn sì běn shū
 1SG read-PFT three CL. book but BÌNG NEG read four CL. book
 ‘I read three books, but not four.’ ***bìng bù*: ✓ negating a stronger alternative**
 (‘I read three books’ **does not entail** ‘I read four books’, a stronger alternative.)
- (12) #我看了三_F本书, (但) 并没看两本书
 wǒ kàn-le sān běn shū (dàn) bìng méi kàn liǎng běn shū
 1SG read-PFT three CL. book but BÌNG NEG read two CL. book

¹Regarding (9), the current paper has a different view from Wu (2025). In my view, (9) is not self-contradictory.

Intended: ‘I read three books, but not two.’ ***bìng bù*: # negating a weaker alternative**
 (‘I read three books’ entails ‘I read two books’, a weaker alternative.)

The use of *bìng bù* in (13) is felicitous, because here, with the use of a free relative (‘what I read’), the numbers ‘three’ and ‘two’ are interpreted exhaustively, providing the most informative answer in addressing ‘what I read’. Thus the prejacent of *bìng bù*, i.e., ‘what I read is two books’, is not an already entailed proposition.

- (13) 我 看 的 是 三_F 本 书, 并 不 是 两 本 书
 wǒ kàn de shì sān běn shū bìng bú shì liǎng běn shū
 1SG read LINKER COPULA three CL. book BÌNG NEG COPULA two CL. book
 ‘What I read is three books, not two.’
 (‘What I read is three books’ and ‘what I read is two books’ do not entail each other.)

In general, *bìng bù* cannot be used to negate or contrast meanings entailed by one’s own utterance. (14) illustrates the negation of asserted meaning, and (15) illustrates the negation of presupposed meaning. In both cases, the use of *bìng bù* is intuitively unacceptable, because, by negating entailed meanings, the speaker contradicts themselves, which is unacceptable.

- (14) Speaker: # 张三 和 李四 都 来了, 但 张三 并 没 来
 Zhāng-Sān hé Lǐ-Sì dōu lái-le dàn Zhāng-Sān bìng méi lái
 Zhāng-Sān and Lǐ-Sì both/all come-PFT but Zhāng-Sān BÌNG NEG come
 Intended: ‘Both Zhāng Sān and Lǐ Sì came, but Zhāng Sān didn’t come.’ **Contradict.**
- (15) Speaker: # 我 的 狗 很 可爱, 但 我 并 没 有 狗
 wǒ de gǒu hěn kě’ài dàn wǒ bìng méi yǒu gǒu
 1SG POSS. dog very cute but 1SG BÌNG NEG have dog
 Intended: ‘My dog is cute, but I don’t have a dog.’ **Contradiction**

Intriguingly, in a dialogue, a speaker can felicitously use *bìng bù* to negate and correct entailed meanings uttered by a different speaker. In the dialogues in (16) and (17), Speaker B corrects what Speaker A says / believes / thinks. These dialogues are natural and coherent, giving no impression of contradiction at all. In fact, they illustrate the primary and most natural way of using *bìng bù*, which is why *bìng bù* is considered a ‘corrective’ particle.

- (16) A: 张三 和 李四 都 来了 B: 张三 并 没 来
 Zhāng-Sān hé Lǐ-Sì dōu lái-le Zhāng-Sān bìng méi lái
 Zhāng-Sān and Lǐ-Sì both/all come-PFT Zhāng-Sān BÌNG NEG come
 Speaker A: ‘Both Zhāng Sān and Lǐ Sì came’. Speaker B: ‘Zhāng Sān didn’t come.’
Speaker B corrects the asserted meaning uttered by Speaker A
- (17) A: 你 的 狗 很 可爱 B: (但) 我 并 没 有 狗
 nǐ de gǒu hěn kě’ài (dàn) wǒ bìng méi yǒu gǒu
 2SG POSS. dog very cute (but) 1SG BÌNG NEG have dog
 Speaker A: ‘Your dog is cute.’ Speaker B: ‘(But) I don’t have a dog.’
Speaker B corrects the presupposed meaning uttered by Speaker A

In the existing literature, Yuan & Liu (2025) do point out that it is only in dialogues that *bìng bù* can be felicitously used to negate / correct truth-conditional meanings (i.e., assertions or presuppositions). However, this empirical difference between single-speaker narration (e.g., (14), (15)) and multi-speaker dialogues (e.g., (16), (17)) is not explained by their analysis.

2.3 Infelicitous uses of *bìng bù*: the absence of sufficient disagreement For *bìng bù* to be used felicitously in a dialogue, there is an additional requirement: a sufficient level of disagreement between the speaker of the *bìng bù*-sentence and interlocutors.

Oftentimes, a certain level of disagreement is easy to accommodate. Thus, in response to a neutral A-not-A question (see (18)) or a question biased towards the truth of *p* (see (19)), it is felicitous to reply with ‘*bìng bù p*’. However, in response to a question biased towards the truth of $\neg p$ (see (20)), a reply containing the corrective marker *bìng bù* sounds degraded, because it’s difficult to accommodate a sufficient level of disagreement. In (20), the accommodation of disagreement clashes with the bias of the question.

- (18) A: 你 有 没有 去过 南极? B: 我 (并) 没 去过
 nǐ yǒu méi-yǒu qù-guò nán-jí wǒ (bìng) méi qù-guò
 2SG have NEG-have go-PST Antarctica 1SG BÌNG NEG go-PST
 A: ‘Have you been to Antarctica?’ B: ‘I haven’t been there.’ **A is neutral**
- (19) A: 你 去过 南极, 是吧? B: 我 (并) 没 去过
 nǐ qù-guò nán-jí shì-ba wǒ (bìng) méi qù-guò
 2SG go-PST Antarctica correct-Q 1SG BÌNG NEG go-PST
 A: ‘You’ve been to Antarctica, haven’t you?’ B: ‘I haven’t been there.’
A assumes that B has been to Antarctica $\leadsto$ there is sufficient disagreement
- (20) A: 你 没 去过 南极, 是吧? B: 我 (?? 并) 没 去过
 nǐ méi qù-guò nán-jí shì-ba wǒ (??bìng) méi qù-guò
 2SG NEG go-PST Antarctica correct-Q 1SG BÌNG NEG go-PST
 A: ‘You haven’t been to Antarctica, have you?’ B: ‘I haven’t been there.’
A assumes that B hasn’t been to Antarctica $\leadsto$ there is no sufficient disagreement

(21) seems to be a counterexample. There is no disagreement between A and B. So, what constitutes the disagreement or contrast that licenses each speaker’s use of *bìng bù*? Here, B has a strong fear regarding the truth of *p* (i.e., A told A’s mother about their relationship), and both B and A aim to reject the truth of *p*. Thus, the contrast or disagreement is not between A and B, but between their utterances and what B fears.

- (21) Context: (Frana & Rawlins 2019’s paranoid scenario) A’s mother doesn’t want B to hang out with A. A and B still want to hang out, but to avoid trouble, B asks A not to tell A’s mother when A comes over. As B opens the door to A, B gets a bit paranoid:
- a. B: 你 (并) 没 告诉 妈妈 你 来 我的 家, 是吧?
 nǐ (bìng) mèi gàosù māmā nǐ lái wǒ-de jiā shì-ba
 2SG (BÌNG) NEG tell mom 2SG come 1SG-POSS home correct-Q
 B: ‘By any chance, you didn’t tell your mother that you were coming over, right?’
- b. A: 当然啦 我 (并) 没 告诉 妈妈
 dāng-rán-la wǒ (bìng) méi gàosù māmā
 of-course 1SG BÌNG NEG tell mom
 A: ‘Of course I didn’t tell my mom.’

To sum up, *bìng bù* requires some contextually salient propositional meaning in order to license a felicitous negation, contrast, or correction. This negation is speaker-oriented, reflecting the speaker’s disagreement. A speaker cannot disagree with their own utterance. A speaker uses *bìng bù* to signal disagreement with others (the hearer or a third party) or to rule out potential over-interpretations (i.e., implicatures or stronger alternatives) of the speaker’s own utterance.

3. Proposal

In the existing literature, *bìng bù* is analyzed as a kind of negation-flavored operator. According to Yuan & Liu (2025), a *bìng-bù*-sentence directly corrects (i.e., negates) existing information in the common ground. According to Wu (2025), *bìng bù p* (i) presupposes a salient proposition *q* that the prejacent of *bìng* (i.e., $\neg p$) contrasts with and (ii) defines ‘contrast’ as a negation based on the implicatures of $\neg p$ and *q*: i.e., $\exists r[q \rightsquigarrow r \wedge \neg p \rightsquigarrow \neg r]$. Obviously, these analyses do not account for the speaker-sensitivity in using *bìng bù* (see (14) vs. (16), and (15) vs. (17)).

Inspired by Frana & Rawlins (2019)’s analysis of Italian *mica*, I propose to analyze *bìng bù* as a speaker-oriented, ‘CG (common-ground) management’ operator.

3.1 The semantics of *bìng bù* The discussion in §2 shows that when used in declaratives, Chinese *bìng bù* is similar to Italian *mica* in at least two respects.² First, in terms of distribution, they are felicitous in a subset of cases where plain negation is also acceptable. Second, in terms of felicity conditions, both require that their prejacent be assumed by some discourse participant, allowing the speaker of a *bìng bù* or *mica* sentence to felicitously disagree.

According to Frana & Rawlins (2019), in a declarative sentence, the CG management content of *mica* is a presupposition on the input context from the speaker’s perspective:

- (22) $\llbracket mica \rrbracket^{c,w} \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \lambda p. \neg p$ (CG_w is a set of propositions publicly accepted in world *w*)
 defined for *p, c, w* only if $\forall w' \in \text{Epi}_{\text{SPEAKER}_c}(w) : (\forall w'' \in \text{Conver}_{\text{SPEAKER}_c}(w') : (p \notin \text{CG}_{w''}))$
 (The speaker is sure that, in all worlds satisfying their conversation goals, *p* is not CG.)

Frana & Rawlins (2019) follow Romero & Han (2004) and assume that the adoption of a CG-management operator in a discourse is a meta-conversational move, subject to a pragmatic, discourse-economy-based constraint: Do not use a meta-conversational move unless necessary (to solve a Quality dilemma, e.g., epistemic conflict, or lack of evidence).

However, in Chinese, *bìng bù* is not the only contrastive particle that a speaker can adopt to express disagreement. A lexical entry like (22), combined with the discourse economy constraint, is insufficient to tease apart contrastive particles such as *bìng bù* and *yòu bù*:

- (23) Context: The professor asks Bill why he didn’t do homework. Bill replies:
- a. 我 并 不 知 道 有 作 业
 wǒ bìng bù zhī-dào yǒu zuò-yè
 1SG BÌNG NEG know have homework
 ‘I didn’t even know there was homework.’ $\rightsquigarrow$ not necessarily an impolite reply
 - b. 我 又 不 知 道 有 作 业
 wǒ yòu bù zhī-dào yǒu zuò-yè
 1SG YÒU NEG know have homework
 ‘I didn’t even know there was homework.’ $\rightsquigarrow$ an impolite reply

Thus I propose that the CG management presupposition of *bìng bù* includes additional content. As shown in (24), $\llbracket bìng bù p \rrbracket$ asserts $\neg p$, but it can only be used if, from the speaker’s epistemic perspective, (i) *p* is likely given the CG (see e.g., Lassiter 2017’s gradability-based analysis of likelihood), and (ii) in all worlds satisfying their conversation goals, *p* is not CG.

²Chinese *bìng bù* and Italian *mica* differ in their use in polar questions, exhibiting different distributions and reflecting different types of prior speaker bias. In this paper, I focus only on the use of *bìng bù* in declaratives.

$$(24) \quad \llbracket \text{bìng bù} \rrbracket^{c,w} \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \lambda p. \neg p, \quad \text{defined for } p, c, w \text{ only if } \underbrace{\forall w' \in \text{Epi}_{\text{SPEAKER}_c}(w)}_{\text{The speaker is sure that}} :$$

$$\underbrace{(\mu_{\text{LIKELY}_{w'}}(p \mid \text{CG}_{w'}) \geq \theta_{c,w'})}_{p \text{ is sufficiently likely given the CG}} \wedge \underbrace{\forall w'' \in \text{Conver}_{\text{SPEAKER}_c}(w') : (p \notin \text{CG}_{w''})}_{\text{in all worlds satisfying their conversation goals, } p \text{ is not CG}}$$

Evidently, due to its presuppositional requirements, *bìng bù* can only be used in a subset of cases where plain negation is acceptable.

The analysis in (24) immediately explains why *bìng bù* is felicitous in negating implicatures, stronger alternatives, and other sufficiently salient information (e.g., in (18), the proposition ‘you’ve been to Antarctica’ involved in the neutral polar question *Have you been to Antarctica?*, and what a certain speaker fears in (21)). The likelihood threshold, $\theta_{c,w'}$, is a free variable, and its value is vague and context-dependent. Thus, given the CG, implicatures are naturally considered likely, and for other salient information, the high-likelihood presupposition can be easily accommodated. However, a high likelihood of p given the CG does not guarantee that p would be added to the CG in worlds that satisfy conversation goals. Therefore, there is no conflict between the two parts of the presupposition.

On the other hand, as addressed in §2.3, if a context lacks sufficient disagreement between the speaker and others, then the use of *bìng bù* sounds degraded (e.g., (20)). Under the current analysis, the lack of disagreement means that, from the speaker’s perspective, given the CG, $\neg p$ is already considered highly likely. This causes difficulty in accommodating the first part of the presupposition (i.e., accommodating high likelihood for p), leading to degradedness.

3.2 The corrective effect of *bìng bù* in dialogues §2.2 has shown that *bìng bù* cannot be used felicitously to negate entailed meanings from one’s own utterance, but in a dialogue, it can be used to negate and correct entailed meanings from a different speaker. The proposal in (24) also naturally explains this empirical difference.

From the speaker’s perspective, if their own utterance entails p , then p is already part of the CG in the entire set of the speaker’s epistemic worlds, which contradicts the second part of the presupposition, namely, that in all worlds satisfying their conversation goals, p is not CG.

However, from the speaker’s perspective, if someone else (e.g., X) utters p , p does not automatically become part of the CG in the speaker’s epistemic worlds. Rather, at this point, the speaker is legitimate to consider that the CG contains ‘ X said p ’. Based on this, the speaker can derive the truth of p as a conversational implicature by invoking the Maxim of Quality: X must be truthful in uttering p , so ‘ X said p ’ implies p is true. Then since p is only an implicature in the speaker’s epistemic worlds, the speaker can felicitously use *bìng bù* to negate p .

Of course, in addition to the Maxim of Quality, the speaker may invoke other Gricean maxims to generate various implicatures and make a denial. A speaker may object to another’s previous utterance on any grounds whatever, including style, register, or phonetic realization. This kind of meta-linguistic correction has been observed by Wu (2025) as well. As illustrated in (25) (Wu 2025: (24c)), by invoking the Maxim of Manner, from ‘A used the pronunciation *fèn-wéi-gǎn*’, B derives the implicature that ‘the pronunciation *fèn-wéi-gǎn* is appropriate and avoids obscurity’. However, by using *bìng bù*, B refuses to add this implicature into the CG.

- (25) A: 李四 是 氛围感 美女. B: 并 不 是 氛围感, 是 氛围感
 Lǐ-Sì shì fèn-wéi-gǎn měi-nǚ bìng bú shì fèn-wéi-gǎn shì fèn-wéi-gǎn
 Lǐ-Sì COP fèn-wéi-gǎn beauty BÌNG NEG COP fèn-wéi-gǎn COP fèn-wéi-gǎn
 A: ‘Lǐ Sì is a *fèn-wéi-gǎn* beauty.’ B: ‘Not *fèn-wéi-gǎn*, but *fèn-wéi-gǎn*.’

3.3 The contrastive effect of *bìng bù* and the role of negation Intuitively, the sentences in (26)–(30) below all convey contrast or counter-expectation. But what is contrast precisely? Here I make a brief comparison between Chinese *dàn* ‘but’ and *bìng bù* and identify a subtype of contrast: anti-additivity, i.e., preventing an expected additive development of the CG.

The data below immediately reveal a key difference between *dàn* ‘but’ (see (26) and (27)) and *bìng bù* (see (28)–(30)): *dàn* ‘but’ does not require its preadjacent be negative, while what follows *bìng* needs to contain sentential negation (see especially (29) vs. (30)).³

- (26) 外面 在下雨, 但 我 没 有 伞
wài-miàn zài xià-yǔ dàn wǒ méi yǒu sǎn
outside at rain but 1SG NEG have umbrella
‘It’s raining outside, but I have no umbrella.’ ✓ **counter-exceptional *dàn* ‘but’ + NEG**
- (27) 外面 在下雨, 但 我 有 伞
wài-miàn zài xià-yǔ dàn wǒ yǒu sǎn
outside at rain but 1SG have umbrella
‘It’s raining outside, but I have an umbrella.’ ✓ **counter-exception without NEG**
- (28) 外面 在下雨, 我 并 没 有 伞
wài-miàn zài xià-yǔ wǒ méi yǒu sǎn
outside at rain 1SG BÌNG NEG have umbrella
‘It’s raining outside. I have no umbrella.’ ✓ ***bìng* + NEG**
- (29) 外面 在下雨, 我 (*并) 有 伞
wài-miàn zài xià-yǔ wǒ (*bìng) yǒu sǎn
outside at rain 1SG BÌNG have umbrella
intended: ‘It’s raining outside. I have an umbrella.’ # ***bìng* without NEG**
- (30) 外面 在下雨, 我 并 不 是 没 有 伞
wài-miàn zài xià-yǔ wǒ bìng bú shì méi yǒu sǎn
outside at rain 1SG BÌNG NEG COPULA NEG have umbrella
‘It’s raining outside. It’s not that I have no umbrella.’ ✓ ***bìng* + double NEG**

Human language processing involves an interplay between top-down prediction and bottom-up information integration. In both production and comprehension, we form expectations across various dimensions: lexical choice, syntactic structures, relevance to the current QUD (Question Under Discussion), and the development of the CG. Naturally, different kinds of contrastive particles can be adopted to reverse or block different kinds of expectations. Specifically, Chinese *dàn* targets QUD relevance, whereas *bìng bù* manages the CG.

In (26) and (27), the contrastive interpretation hinges on the lexical meanings of *rain* and *umbrella*, their semantic relatedness in our conceptual knowledge, and how this semantic relatedness is relevant to the QUD. The felicity in using *dàn* depends on whether one can naturally identify a QUD such that the two clauses connected by *dàn* contribute to the resolution of the QUD in opposite ways (see also Toosarvandani 2014 on the counter-expectational use of *but*).

For example, (26) is felicitous when addressing whether reality aligns with desire: ‘raining’ evokes the need for an umbrella in the speaker’s bouletic worlds, but in the actual world,

³According to Toosarvandani (2014), English *but* has at least three uses: counter-expectation, semantic opposition, and correction. The *dàn*-sentences in (26) and (27) correspond closely to the counter-exceptional use of English *but*. The ‘downplaying’ effect of Chinese *bìng bù* (see §4) resembles the corrective use of English *but*, which similarly requires sentential negation (see (2) and (3)). A detailed cross-linguistic comparison among English *but*, Chinese *dàn*, and Chinese *bìng bù* is left for future research.

there is no umbrella. (27) is felicitous when evaluating the difficulty of going out: ‘raining’ suggests a level of hardship, but the possession of an umbrella mitigates that difficulty. Obviously, this kind of QUD-level contrast is largely grounded in lexical semantics below the level of a full clause, and does not necessarily require sentential negation. Using negation or antonyms can be equally felicitous in establishing this QUD-level contrast:

- (31) a. Mary wants to be a basketball player, but she is not tall.
b. Mary wants to be a basketball player, but she is short.

The proposed analysis in (24) attributes the contrastive effect of *bìng bù* to CG management. The contrast arises between (i) the salience and high likelihood of a certain proposition, *p*, given the current CG in the speaker’s epistemic worlds, and (ii) the speaker’s rejection of *p* from the CG in worlds that satisfy conversation goals. Thus, the use of *bìng bù* in (28)/(30) is felicitous when the proposition ‘I have an/no umbrella’ is salient and strongly expected.

Since *bìng bù* is a CG-management operator, it applies to a whole proposition and blocks its addition to the CG. When applied to an already negative proposition (e.g., (29)/(30)), it results in a double negation that cannot collapse into a simple positive proposition, because *bìng bù* does more than flip truth values — it prevents an expected additive development of the CG.

4. Extension: The ‘downplaying’ effect of Chinese *bìng bù* and Korean *talun anila*

The proposed ‘anti-additive’ analysis of contrast can be extended to account for a slightly different use of *bìng bù* and the use of Korean *talun anila* (or *talun-key anila*). In (32)/(33), *bìng bù* and *talun-key anila* convey a ‘downplaying’ effect. The speaker asks interlocutors not to over-interpret his absence, attributing it simply to bad weather rather than more significant causes.

This preventative downplaying arises from the interplay between additivity (brought by *bìng / talun*) and negation (brought by *bù / anila*). Alternatives to bad weather are explicitly ruled out, thus blocking stronger interpretations (e.g., there are other factors beyond bad weather). Similar phenomena are found in English, typically with the contrastive particle *but* (see (34)).

- (32) 我 并 不 是 不 想 去 (只) 是 天 气 不 好
wǒ bìng bù shì bù xiǎng qù, (zhǐ) shì tiānqì bù hǎo
1SG BÌNG NEG COPULA NEG want go (only) COPULA weather NEG good
‘It’s not that I didn’t want to go. It’s just that the weather was not good.’
- (33) talun-key anila, (kunyang) nalssi-ka an coh-ase mos ka-ss-e
other NEG (just) weather-NOM NEG good-BECAUSE cannot go-PST-DEC.INFM
‘It’s not for other reasons – I didn’t go just because the weather was not good.’
- (34) It’s not for other reasons, but (simply / just) due to bad weather.

These data shed light on two issues. First, by including an additive particle, the CG management of *bìng bù* (and *talun-key anila*) is probably not always presuppositional (see (24)), but can be post-suppositional. The base part (e.g., bad weather) can be mentioned after the additive part is first ruled out. This post-suppositional mechanism is attested in the use of many additive particles (see Brasoveanu & Szabolcsi 2013). Second, in (32) and (33), the use of exclusive-flavored particles *zhǐ* ‘only’ and *kunyang* ‘just’ is optional, and the downplaying effect remains without them. This suggests that anti-additivity not just creates contrast (against expectation), but attempts to lower expectations, much like *only* and *just* do. This might explain why, cross-linguistically, contrastive particles (e.g., *but*, Chinese *dàn*) are often also exclusive particles.

5. Summary and discussion: various contrastive particles and contrastive effects

This paper focuses on Chinese contrastive particle *bìng bù* and extends the discussion to Korean *talum anila* / *talun-key anila*. Both particles convey contrastive meaning via anti-additivity, constraining meaning strengthening and disrupting interlocutors' otherwise natural expectations. These constraints on meaning strengthening are speaker-oriented and operate as CG management.

Along the discussion, I have shown that natural languages employ a variety of contrastive particles at different levels. While *bìng bù* functions as a CG management particle, Chinese *dàn* probably serves as a QUD-level contrastive particle. I have also identified anti-additivity as a mechanism of generating contrast. This idea suggests a close connection between contrastive particles and exclusive-flavored markers such as *only*, *but*, *just*, etc. A comprehensive investigation of related phenomena and their underlying mechanisms is left for future research.

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